

Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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Abstract

Sociologists have long debated the nature of “good” and “bad” taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies BERTopic to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions and examples. I identify distinct cultural models for “good taste” (e.g., Subjectivity, Aesthetics, Fashion) and “bad taste” (e.g., Dislike, Poor Choices, Vulgarity). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, moralized cultural models (e.g., citing Donald Trump or the Obamas) are associated with a heightened propensity to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of “good” and “bad” taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by three primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define and provide examples of “good taste” and “bad taste”?
2. How do cultural models of good taste relate to cultural models of bad taste? Are they structurally coupled into broader cultural logics?
3. How do these taste cultural models map onto specific cultural domains (e.g., beer, classical music, wrestling)?

3 Methods

Data for this study are drawn from an open-access dataset originally collected by Bonard et al. (2024). In this study, researchers collected data from a representative sample of the US adult population ($N = 297$) through the *Prolific Academic* platform. After screening for data quality using four attention checks, the final sample comprised 241 participants (124 men, 114 women, 3 other; $M_{age} = 44.92$, $SD_{age} = 16.12$). In their survey, respondents were asked whether they distinguish between good and bad taste in their daily lives. The overwhelming majority of the sample (93%, $N = 224$) answered affirmatively. This subset was then asked to provide brief, open-ended definitions and concrete examples of both concepts.

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter “documents”), I used **BERTopic**. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., “good,” “bad,” “taste,” “don’t”) were removed from each document because these words—mostly paraphrasing the original question—were overwhelmingly common across documents and thus did little to differentiate them. We also remove common English stop words from each document (e.g., the, it, is, do, etc.). The algorithm was optimized for each of the four text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring. Finally, cross-tabulations and domain-distinction Likert scale heatmaps were generated to examine the coherence of these classifications.

4 Results

4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

The BERTopic models identified distinct cultural models for definitions and examples. For **Good Taste**, respondents defined the concept primarily through *Similarity/Subjectivity* (homophily), *Aesthetics*, or *Style/Quality*. When asked for concrete examples, the clusters were much richer, featuring groups who cited *Fashion/Decor* (friends and spouses), *Refinement/Art* (creators like Steve Jobs), *Musical Knowledge*, or even specific public figures representing class like *The Obamas*.

Topic	Count	Name	Keywords
-1	32	-1_fashion_trendy_style_appreciate	fashion, trendy, style, appreciate, clothes, opinion, music, say, art, prefer
0	113	0_say_mean_usually_subjective	say, mean, usually, subjective, food, quality, enjoy, sense, certain, similar
1	62	1_art_appreciate_choices_shows	art, appreciate, choices, shows, look, enjoy, understand, pleasing, appealing, gaudy
2	16	2_interact_services_selection_look	interact, services, selection, look, style, way, choices, goods, interests, dress

Table 1: Good Taste Summary Table

Topic	Count	Name	Keywords	Example Responses
-1	32	-1_fashion_trendy_style_appreciate	fashion, trendy, style, appreciate, clothes, opinion, music, say, art, prefer	Outfits
0	113	0_say_mean_usually_subjective	say, mean, usually, subjective, food, quality, enjoy, sense, certain, similar	• "I think that a person who has good taste can easily influence a lot of people. I also think that they are very smart in knowing what their audience want. They follow modern trends and stay the good and bad" • "Usually, those someone has good taste I consider their likes/dislikes to be similar to mine, because I believe that I have good taste."
1	62	1_art_appreciate_choices_shows	art, appreciate, choices, shows, look, enjoy, understand, pleasing, appealing, gaudy	• "This person can distinguish good art from bad art. This person has seen and learned a lot in this professional area." • "As artist, as it may sound, I've associated someone having good taste as someone rather cultured. Their preferences are somewhat robust, and with a sense of conservatism. It's not loud, garish, or pretentious."
2	16	2_interact_services_selection_look	interact, services, selection, look, style, way, choices, goods, interests, dress	• "I think that their taste good, stylish choices based on the type of aesthetic that I myself appreciate. They also think is creative ways that complement their choices as a whole" • "The have knowledge and range in the ways they prefer"

Table 2: Good Taste Examples Table

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through *Subjective Dislike*, *Poor Choices/Lack of Effort*, *Tackiness/Gaudiness*, *Low-Brow Media*, or *Poor Manners/Immorality*. Concrete examples similarly ranged from *Poor Fashion*, *Derivative Media* (e.g., formulaic filmmakers), to specific instances of *Vulgarity* (often citing Donald Trump).

Topic	Count	Name	Keywords
-1	38	-1_quality_poor_dont_art	quality, poor, dont, art, understanding, clothing, usually, value, negative, content
0	106	0_say_dont_likes_example	say, dont, likes, example, usually, does, different, mean, doesnt, opinion
1	61	1_dont_choices_care_make	dont, choices, care, make, maybe, poorly, gaudy, art, value, andor
2	18	2_loud_sense_colors_shows	loud, sense, colors, shows, qualities, character, boo, drama, bold, similar

Table 3: Bad Taste Summary Table

4.2 Cross-Schema Cultural Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent “logics,” I cross-tabulated respondents’ primary cultural models across the four questions. The associations are highly significant. For instance, a respondent’s definition of Good Taste strongly predicts their definition of Bad Taste ($\chi^2 = 111.60, p < 0.001$). Individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity overwhelmingly define bad taste simply as subjective dislike.

Similarly, the examples respondents choose are highly correlated ($\chi^2 = 99.01, p < 0.001$). Respondents who cite a friend’s “Fashion/Decor” as an example of good taste are highly likely to cite “Poor Fashion” as an example of bad taste. Respondents who point to “Refinement/Art” for good taste are much more likely to point to “Derivative Media” for bad

Topic	Good Taste	Bad Taste
0	0_say_mean_usually_subjective	0_say_dont_likes_example
1	1_art_appreciate_choices_shows	1_dont_choices_care_make
2	2_interact_services_selection_look	2_loud_sense_colors_shows

Table 4: Bad Taste Examples Table

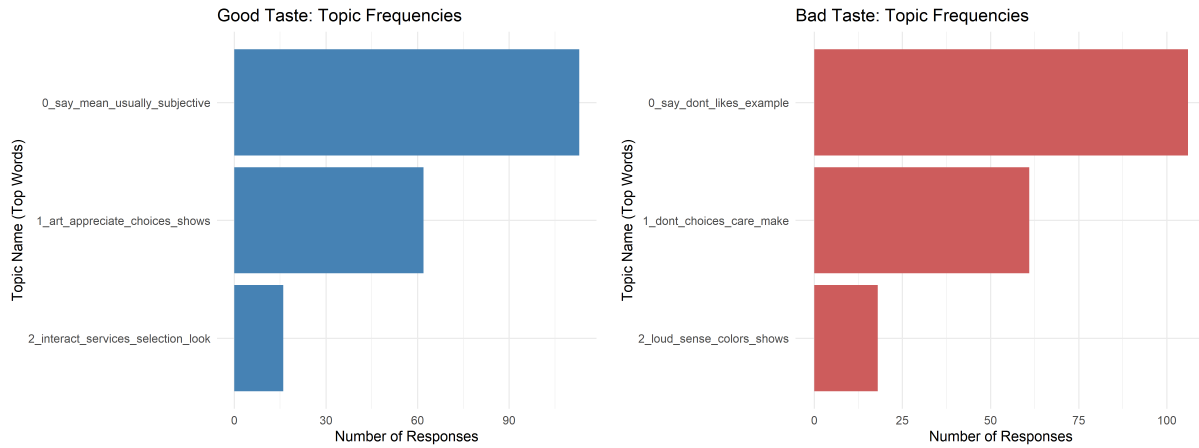


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

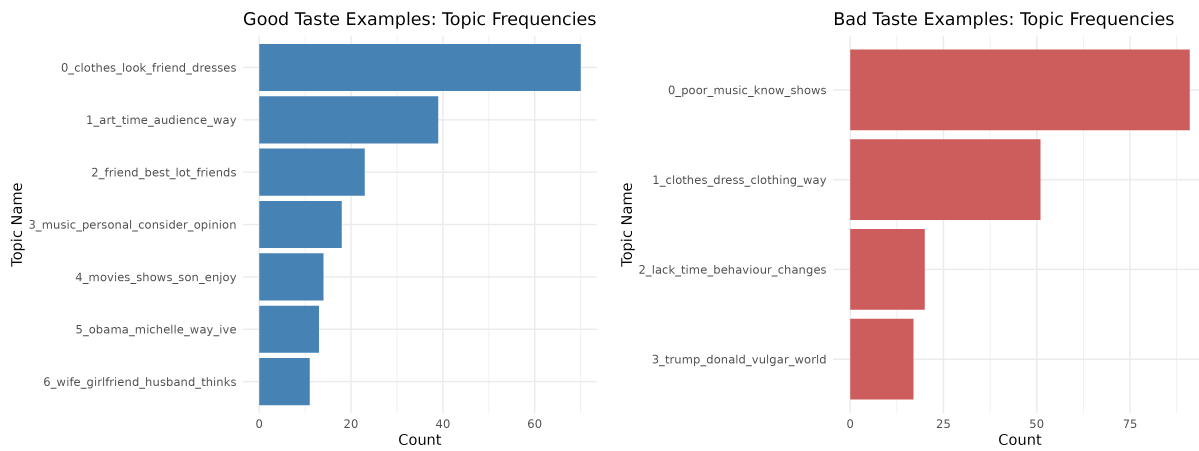


Figure 2: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Examples)

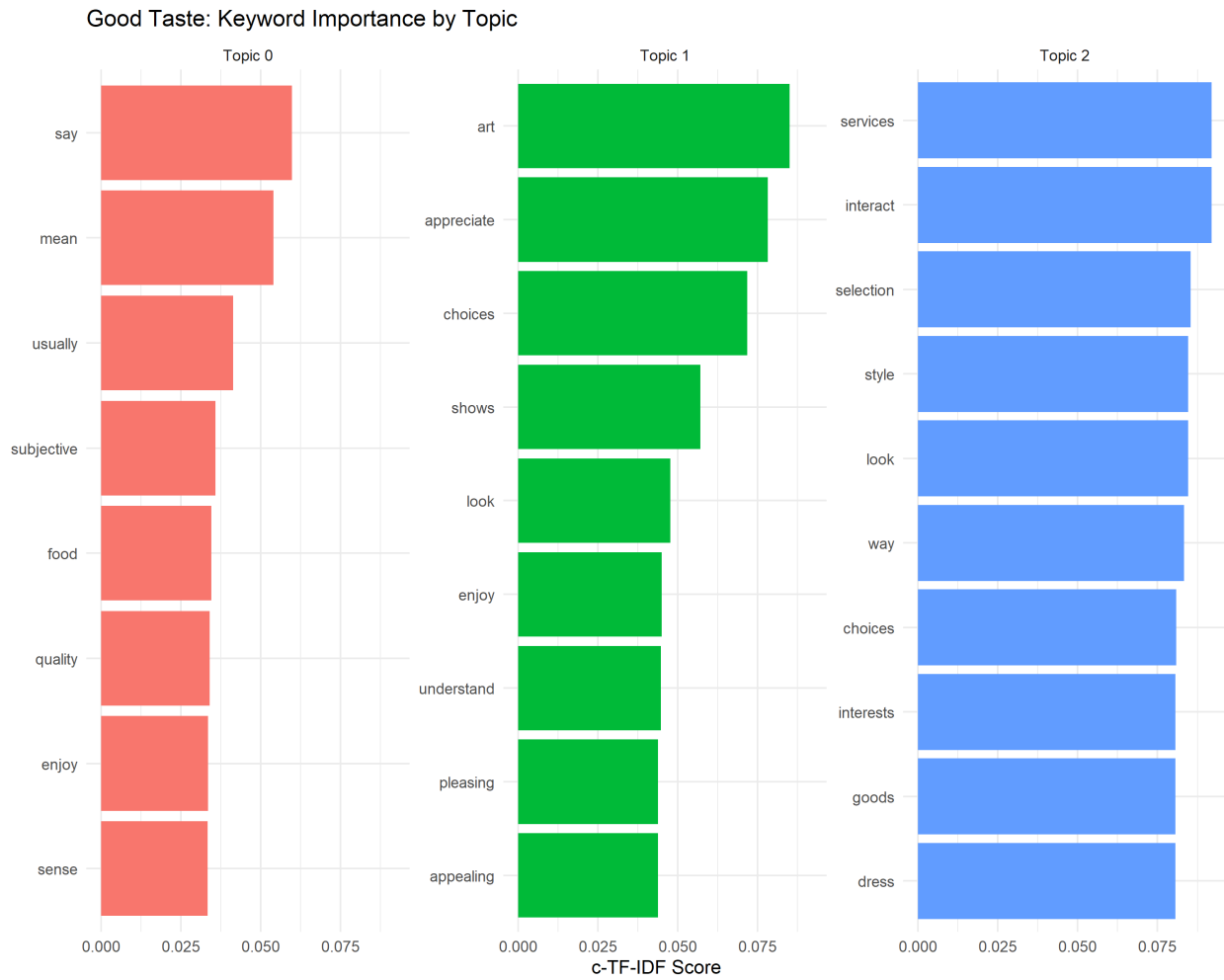


Figure 3: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Good Taste Topics (Definitions)

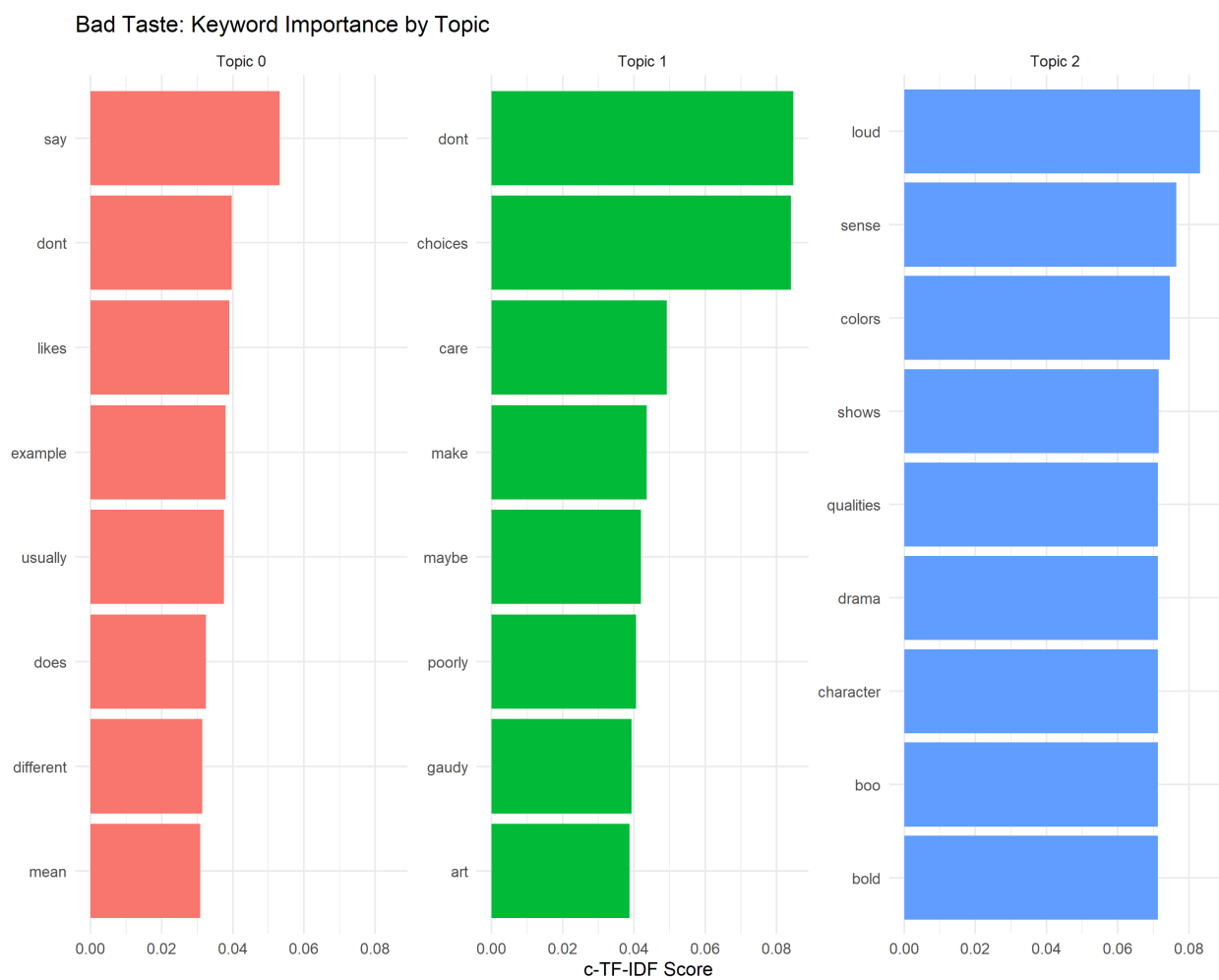


Figure 4: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Bad Taste Topics (Definitions)

Good Taste Examples: Keyword Importance

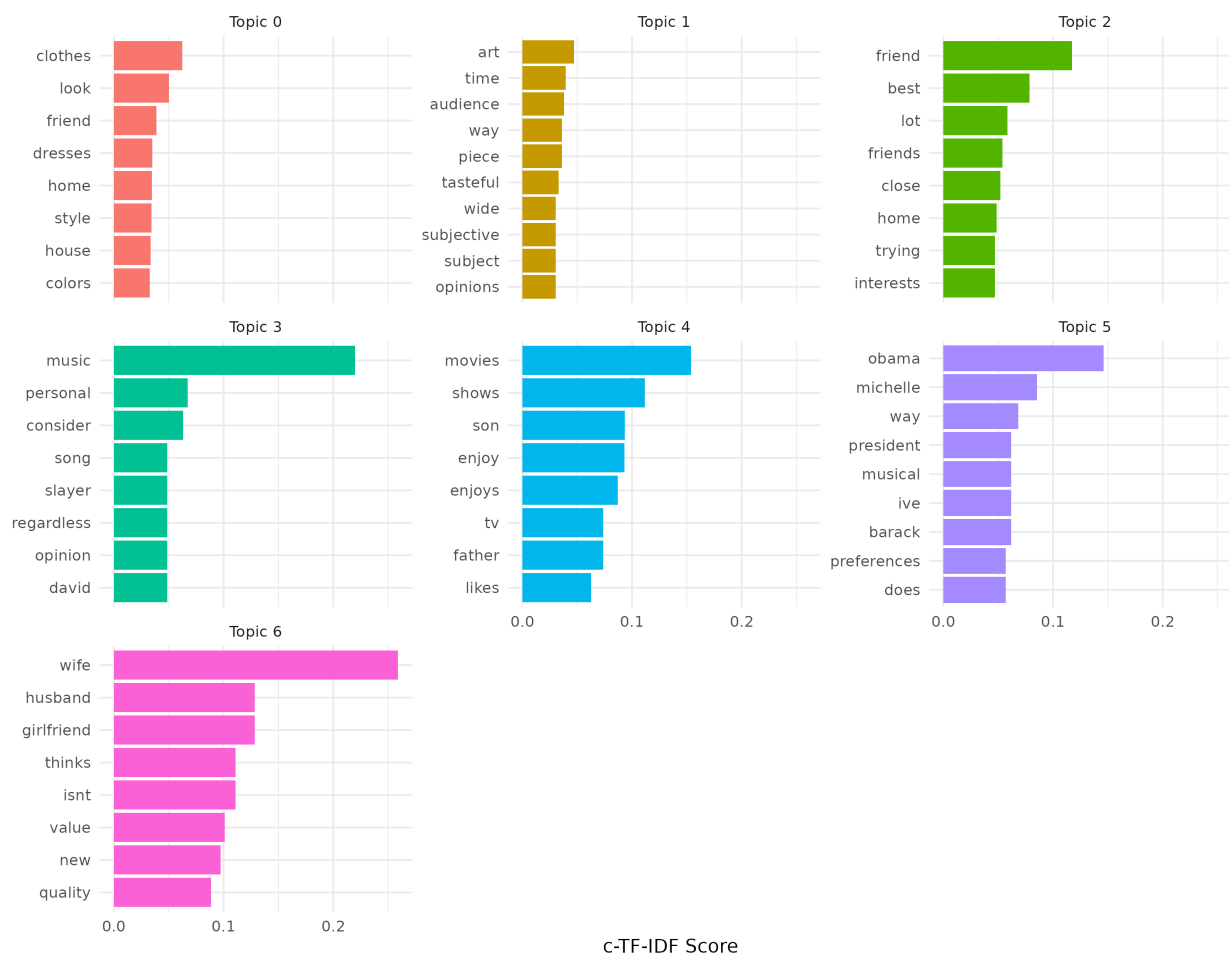


Figure 5: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Good Taste Topics (Examples)

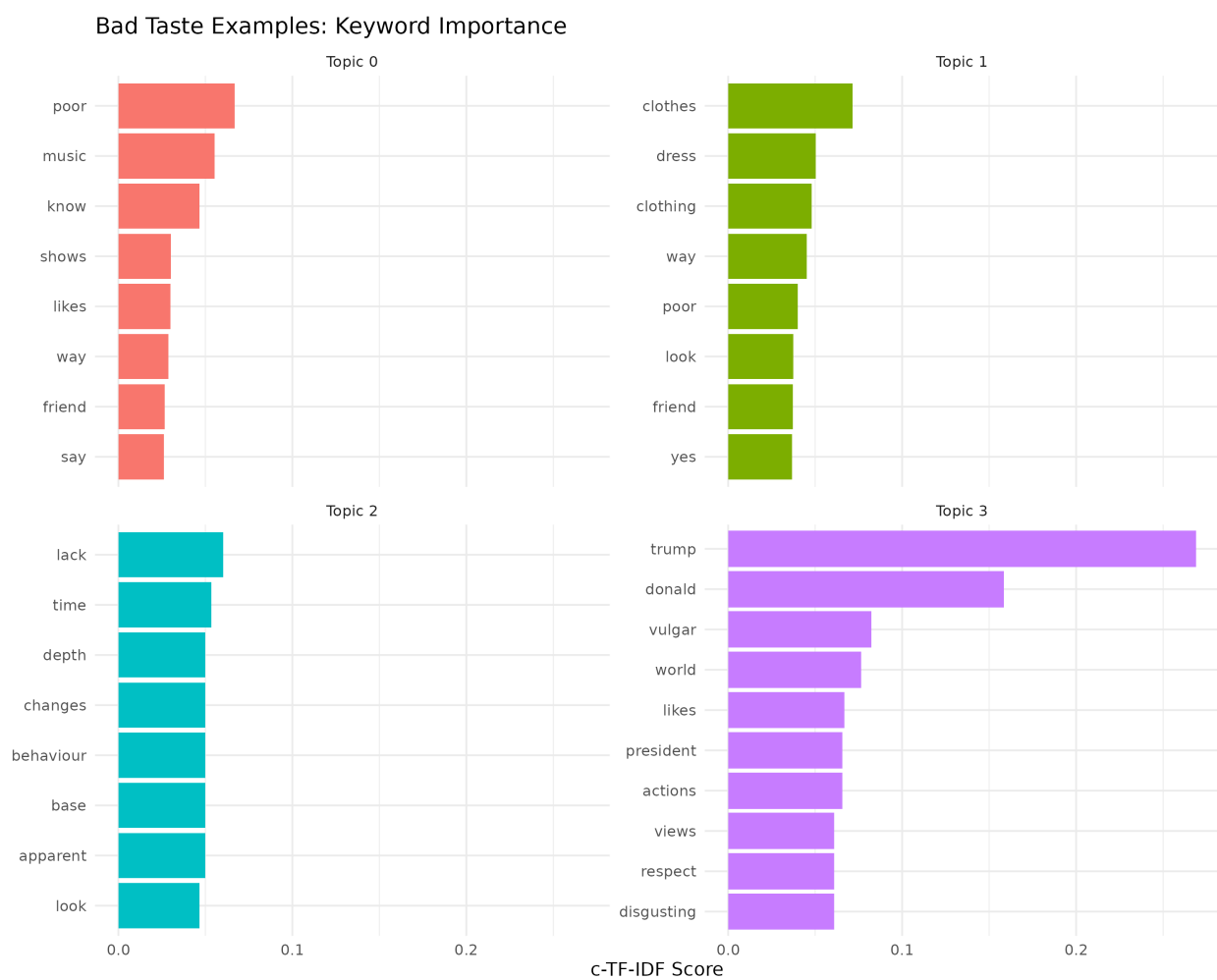


Figure 6: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Bad Taste Topics (Examples)

taste. This symmetry indicates that people deploy consistent criteria—whether aesthetic, material, or subjective—across moral valences.

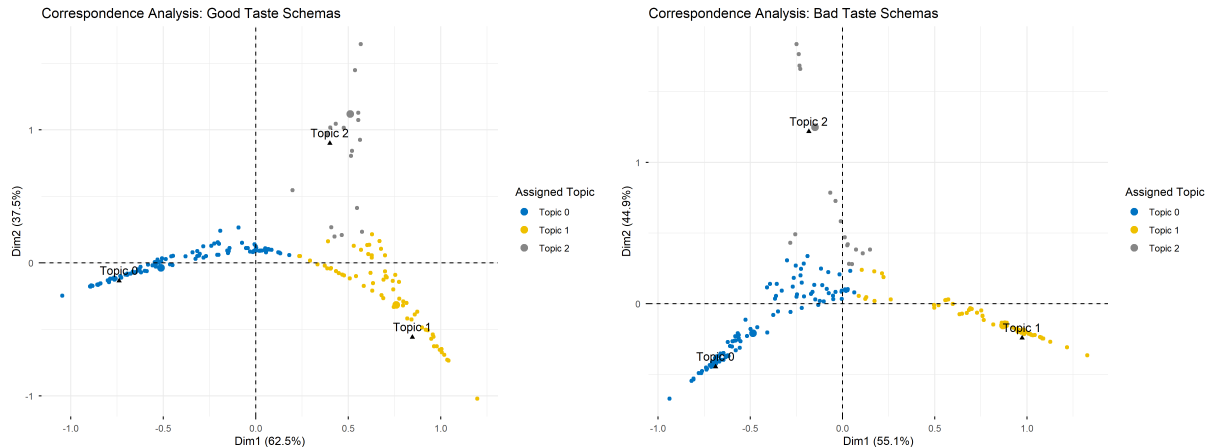


Figure 7: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Schemas (Definitions)

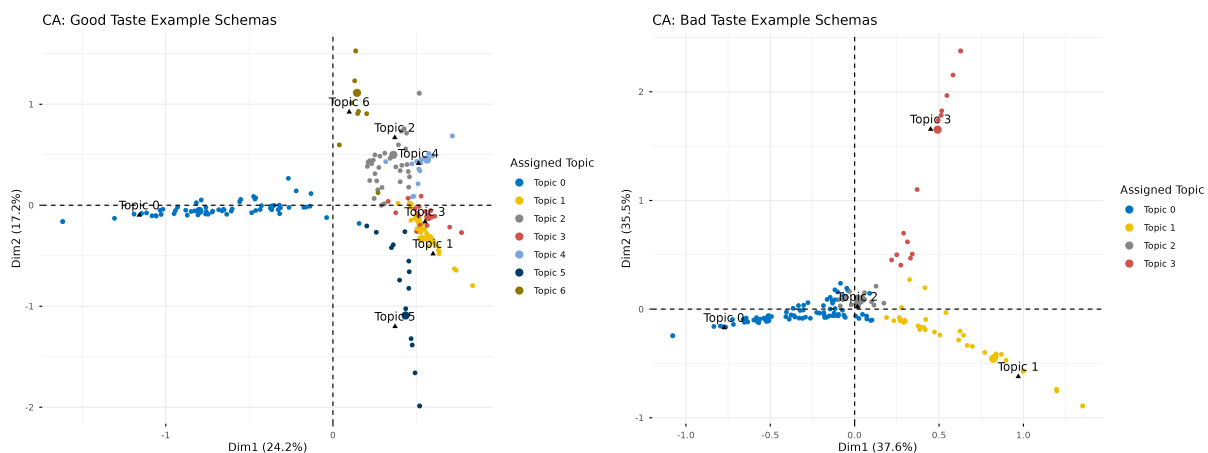


Figure 8: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Schemas (Examples)

4.3 Demographics

4.4 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it “makes sense” to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the schema, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

However, there is critical variance in boundary intensity. Respondents whose examples of good taste clustered around *The Obamas/Class*, and whose bad taste clustered around



Figure 9: Pearson Residuals of Schema Correlation

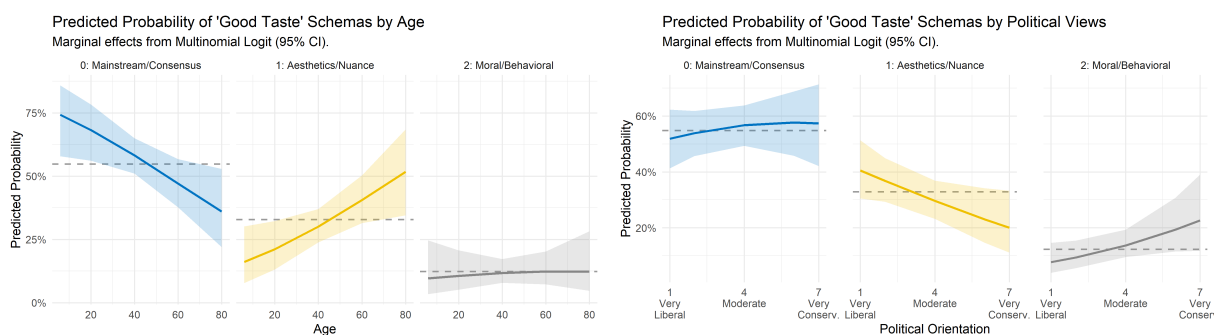


Figure 10: Predicted Probability of Good Taste Schemas by Age and Political Views

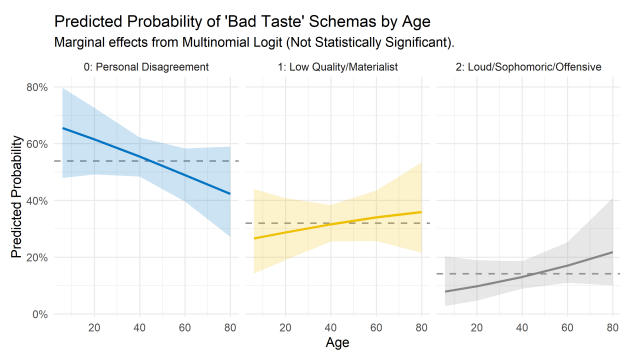


Figure 11: Predicted Probability of Bad Taste Schemas by Age

Model	Predictor	Wald χ^2	Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	Age	2.96	2	0.2274
Good Taste Def	Gender	1.74	2	0.4198
Good Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	0.08	2	0.9630
Good Taste Def	Political	1.24	2	0.5380
Bad Taste Def	Age	7.17	5	0.2085
Bad Taste Def	Gender	1.91	5	0.8619
Bad Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	5.64	5	0.3428
Bad Taste Def	Political	4.86	5	0.4329
Good Taste Example	Age	12.90	6	0.0447
Good Taste Example	Gender	4.21	6	0.6480
Good Taste Example	EducationLevel_Coded	9.36	6	0.1544
Good Taste Example	Political	8.14	6	0.2280
Bad Taste Example	Age	5.90	3	0.1165
Bad Taste Example	Gender	0.37	3	0.9463
Bad Taste Example	EducationLevel_Coded	3.29	3	0.3494
Bad Taste Example	Political	2.88	3	0.4111

Table 5: Multinomial Logistic Regression Wald Tests for Topic Predictors

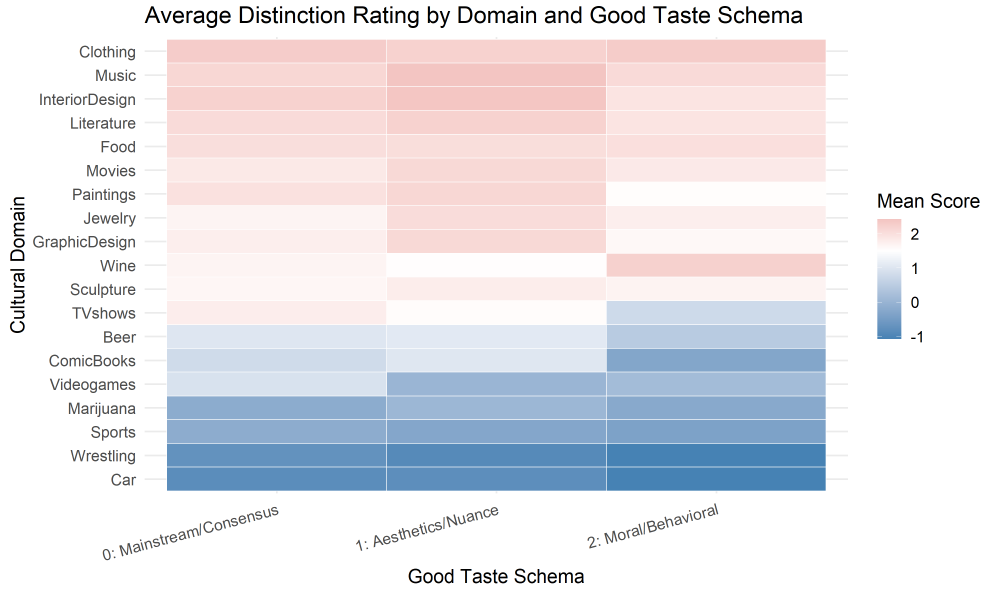


Figure 12: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Schema

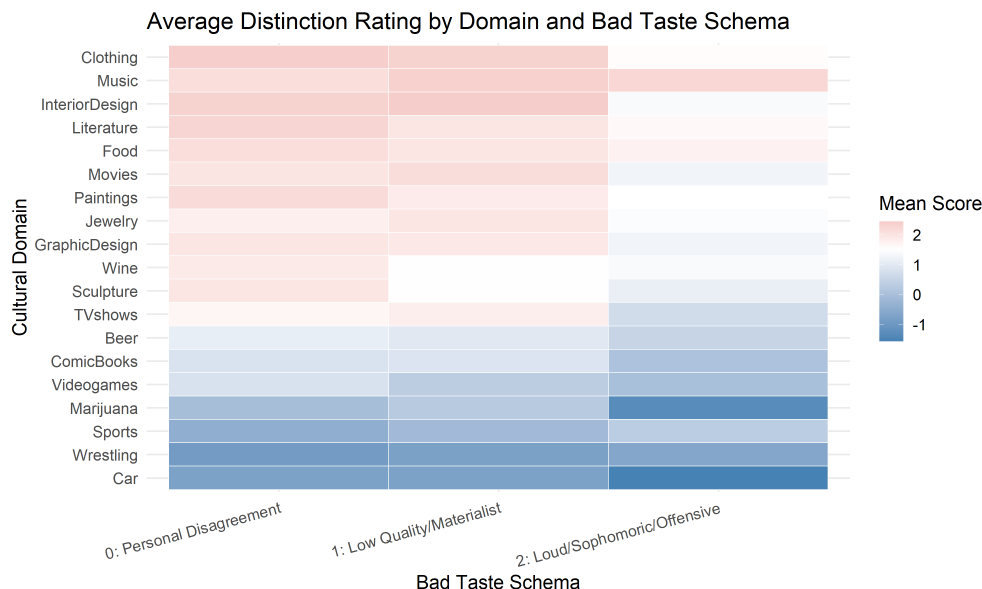


Figure 13: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Schema

Trump/Vulgarity, reported much higher propensity to draw taste distinctions across almost *all* domains, including peripheral ones like Food and Literature. This suggests that when folk models of taste become moralized or politicized, the boundaries of cultural distinction harden and expand across everyday life.

5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, homophilous, and moral dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

References

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